

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 145

Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 6 Wangeci's Story: A Widow Among Women

I kept going to dances for a long time before I got married. It is not like now when a man comes to a girl's place one day and the next day they get married—no, it took years. Many used to come and visit, and I would go meet others at dances. That is the way I saw my husband—there in the dances.

[159](#)
[Life History Materials](#)

[584](#)
[Arranging A Marriage](#)

[832](#)
[Sexual Stimulation](#)

He did not know our home, so he asked his friends. Then he came near the granary in our homestead and stood there. Us, we were in the kitchen giving stories and cracking jokes—making a lot of noise. Then he started blowing his nose for the first time. My mother heard it and told us to keep quiet. When we did, we heard him blow his nose again. We kept quiet and he blew it a third time—like this [she covers one nostril with her thumb and blows loud]. Our mother told me to go and see who was there, because I was the only girl in the kitchen with the women.

[159](#)
[Life History Materials](#)

[584](#)
[Arranging A Marriage](#)

I went, and after seeing who it was I asked him why he had come. He told me, "To visit." I asked, "To visit whom?" Then he told me, "To visit you." He thought I would not mind. Because it was the first day he visited, I did not ask him a lot of questions. I told him to go in peace and that he should not be abused—meaning that he was welcome to come again.

[159](#)
[Life History Materials](#)

[574](#)
[Visiting And Hospitality](#)

[584](#)
[Arranging A Marriage](#)

He stayed for three days without coming back and on the fourth day he came again. He did the same thing, blowing his nose. Because I knew who it was, I went out to see him. We talked awhile, and then he left. After the fourth time of visiting me this way, my mother asked, "This man who is always coming here, who is he and what does he want?" I told her about him.

159
Life History Materials

584
Arranging A Marriage

The next time he came, I asked him who he was—his mother, his father, and his clan, all the particulars, even if I knew them already. I knew that if he was really interested he would come another day and tell me what he had been told by his parents, and I would tell him what I was told by mine. Then the friendship [relationship] would be established. When we had done that he had gone and told his parents about my parents and clan, he came back and said that our clans intermarry.

159
Life History Materials

582
Regulation Of
Marriage

584
Arranging A Marriage

From then on, he began watching my steps—when I was cultivating, he would send a group to come and see how much I could work to  146 know if I was hardworking or lazy. He even watched to see if I stayed at home and did not wander. He did this until he learned about me fully. Finally, he came one day and asked for tobacco. I went for it from my father [father's younger brother] and gave it to him. If I had not liked him, I would have told him to go away. He took the tobacco to his father, and his father told him to make some beer to take to my father to pay him back for the tobacco. That is how we used to get married—not like today when a boy loves a girl, they go to his home and she starts cooking for him right away.

156
Social Personality

159
Life History Materials

584
Arranging A Marriage

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